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My teammates

These are the guys who influenced me … and one whom I could never quite figure out.

Since I started playing senior cricket – as a 16-year-old for Western Province in 1990, and then in 1996 for the Proteas – I've obviously come across some characters in this interesting and pretty long career of mine. Unfortunately, I've only got to know a handful of them really well, through no fault of my own, I assure you. There are not many people easier to get along with than Herschelle Gibbs.

The reality of international cricket, though, is that you don't actually socialise much with players from other teams. I know the rugby guys hang out with each other quite a bit, but they only see each other for 80 minutes on the field, before they are off to the next game. Not only are we playing five-day Test matches against the opposition, but sometimes we're touring their country for a couple of months. You see the guys nearly every day, so you don't really want to be socialising with them too.

Having said that, the Indian Premier League has changed this situation somewhat, and more friendships have been struck among players of different nationalities. The IPL has certainly broken down barriers, even with some of the Indian, Sri Lankan and Pakistani guys, whose English isn't that good.

For example, until the IPL, I'd never really got to know any of the Aussies. We never spent time with them off the pitch, even if they stayed in the same hotel as us, but this has changed with the advent of the IPL. I've become good friends with Adam Gilchrist (more about him later in this